

HEALING FOR THE HOMES SERIES

LORD, WHAT IS FORGIVENESS?

Forgive as the Lord
forgave you.

— COLOSSIANS 3:13



Overcomers
Global Network

EDUCATE . EQUIP . EVOLVE

BY PROPHET JOSHUA MATTHEWS

DEDICATION

This booklet is dedicated to every person carrying the crushing weight of unforgiveness — whether toward someone who wronged you, or toward yourself. You have held onto this pain long enough. It is time to let it go — not for their sake, but for yours. Forgiveness is the key that unlocks the prison you didn't know you were sitting in.

A MESSAGE FROM THE FOUNDER

Dear friend,

Forgiveness is one of the most misunderstood words in the Christian faith. People hear "forgive" and they think it means "pretend it didn't happen" or "let them get away with it." That is not what forgiveness is. And I know that, because I have had to forgive people who hurt me in ways that made me question everything — my calling, my worth, even my relationship with God.

I wrote this booklet because the Holy Spirit put it on my heart to help you understand what forgiveness truly is — and what it is not. When you understand it, it will change the way you live. It will free your mind, your body, and your spirit in ways that medicine cannot.

Do not rush through these pages. Let them work on you slowly, like rain on dry ground. God is about to set you free from a burden you were never meant to carry.

With all my love in Christ,

Joshua Matthews

Founder, Overcomers Global Network

The Cry of the Soul

They hurt you. And it wasn't the kind of hurt that fades with time — it was the kind that carves itself into your memory like letters etched in stone.

Maybe it was a parent who should have protected you but didn't. A spouse who vowed faithfulness and chose betrayal. A friend who smiled to your face and destroyed you behind your back. A church leader who used their position to wound instead of heal.

Or maybe the person you cannot forgive is yourself. Maybe you carry a guilt so heavy that every time you close your eyes, the same scene plays on repeat — the choice you made, the words you said, the damage you caused — and you cannot find a way to release yourself from the verdict you've pronounced over your own life.

Either way, unforgiveness has become your constant companion. It sits in the chair beside you at dinner. It lies next to you at night. It follows you into worship and whispers, "How can you praise God when you hate them? How can God forgive you when you can't forgive yourself?"

And so you've learned to live with it. You've buried it deep enough that most people can't see it. But you feel it — in your tight jaw, in your short temper, in the wall you've built around your heart that won't let anyone in because the last person you let in burned the house down.

Child of God, I am not going to tell you to "just forgive and move on." That is not how healing works. But I am going to show you what forgiveness truly is — and by the time you finish this booklet, the Holy Spirit is going to give you the power to do what your flesh cannot.

What the Bible Says

Let me begin by showing you what forgiveness is *not*, because confusion on this point has kept millions of believers in bondage.

Forgiveness is not saying what they did was okay. It was not okay. Sin is never okay. God never asks you to call evil good.

Forgiveness is not forgetting. The phrase "forgive and forget" is not in the Bible. God gave you a memory for a reason — including the ability to learn from what hurt you so you can protect yourself in the future.

Forgiveness is not reconciliation. You can forgive someone and still choose not to have a relationship with them. Forgiveness is a heart issue between you and God. Reconciliation requires two willing parties.

Forgiveness is not weakness. It is one of the strongest things a human being can do. It takes no strength to hold a grudge — bitterness is easy. Forgiveness requires supernatural power.

So what is forgiveness?

Forgiveness is the decision to release another person from the debt they owe you — and to hand the verdict over to God. It is saying, "What you did wounded me deeply. I am not excusing it. But I am choosing to stop carrying it, because the weight is killing me, and I trust God to be the judge."

""Beloved, do not avenge yourselves, but rather give place to wrath; for it is written, 'Vengeance is Mine, I will repay,' says the Lord.""

— **Romans 12:19 (NKJV)**

Forgiveness is not letting them off the hook. It is taking yourself off the hook — and letting God handle the rest.

Jesus made forgiveness central to His teaching — not because He didn't understand pain, but because He understood it better than anyone who has ever lived. He was betrayed by one of His closest friends, abandoned by His disciples, falsely accused, beaten, mocked, and nailed to a cross by the very people He came to save. And from that cross, with nails in His wrists and blood running down His face, He said:

""Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they do.""

— **Luke 23:34 (NKJV)**

That was not weakness. That was the most powerful act of spiritual warfare in human history. By forgiving His killers in the very act of killing Him, Jesus broke the cycle of vengeance and opened the door for the entire human race to be reconciled to God.

And He calls us to do the same — not to earn salvation, but because unforgiveness destroys the person who holds it.

""For if you forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you. But if you do not forgive men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses.""

— **Matthew 6:14–15 (NKJV)**

This is not a threat. It is a spiritual law. Unforgiveness blocks the flow of God's mercy in your life the same way a clogged pipe blocks water. The water is still flowing from the source — but nothing is getting through because of the blockage. Forgiveness removes the blockage.

Jesus told a parable about a servant who owed his king an unpayable debt — millions in today's currency. The king forgave the entire debt out of compassion. But that same servant went out and grabbed a fellow servant who owed him a small amount and threw him in prison. When the king heard, he said:

""'You wicked servant! I forgave you all that debt because you begged me. Should you not also have had compassion on your fellow servant, just as I had pity on you?' And his master was angry, and delivered him to the torturers until he should pay all that was due to him.""

— **Matthew 18:32–34 (NKJV)**

The "torturers" in this parable are not a metaphor for hell — they are a picture of what unforgiveness does to you *right now*. When you refuse to forgive, you hand yourself over to torment. And that torment is not imaginary.

The Root of the Pain

Medical science has confirmed what Scripture has taught for thousands of years: unforgiveness is toxic — literally.

Research from Johns Hopkins Medicine shows that chronic anger and bitterness trigger the body's stress response, flooding the system with cortisol and adrenaline. Over time, this leads to elevated blood pressure, weakened immune function, increased risk of heart disease, digestive problems, chronic pain, anxiety, and depression.

In other words, unforgiveness does not hurt the person who wronged you. It hurts *you*. You are drinking poison and expecting the other person to get sick.

Psychologically, unforgiveness keeps the wound open. Every time you replay the offense in your mind, your brain and body respond as though it is happening again — right now. The same stress hormones surge, the same pain receptors fire, the same emotional distress floods your system. You are re-traumatizing yourself with a memory, and the person who hurt you may not even know — or care.

Bitterness. Unforgiveness that is left untreated becomes bitterness, and bitterness is a spiritual disease that infects everything it touches. The writer of Hebrews warned:

""Looking carefully lest anyone fall short of the grace of God; lest any root of bitterness springing up cause trouble, and by this many become defiled.""

— **Hebrews 12:15 (NKJV)**

Bitterness is called a "root" because it grows underground. You may not see it at first, but it spreads into your relationships, your worship, your parenting, your marriage — everything. It defiles many, not just you.

The Wound of Betrayal. Betrayal is uniquely devastating because it comes from someone you trusted. The closer the relationship, the deeper the wound. David understood this pain:

""For it is not an enemy who reproaches me; then I could bear it. Nor is it one who hates me who has exalted himself against me; then I could hide

from him. But it was you, a man my equal, my companion and my acquaintance. We took sweet counsel together, and walked to the house of God in the throng."

— **Psalm 55:12–14 (NKJV)**

David was not hurt by a stranger. He was hurt by someone he walked to church with. And that is often the cruelest cut — the one that comes from inside the house of God.

Self-Unforgiveness. Many believers have forgiven others but cannot forgive themselves. They carry a private courtroom in their mind where they are simultaneously the prosecutor, the defendant, and the judge — and the verdict is always guilty.

But here is the truth: if God has forgiven you, and you refuse to forgive yourself, you are placing your judgment above His. You are essentially saying, "God, Your blood wasn't enough for what I did." That is not humility — it is a form of pride, and it keeps you in chains.

"There is therefore now no condemnation to those who are in Christ Jesus, who do not walk according to the flesh, but according to the Spirit."

— **Romans 8:1 (NKJV)**

No condemnation. Not "a little condemnation." Not "condemnation until you've punished yourself enough." No condemnation. If God says you are free, you are free. Stop sentencing yourself to a prison God already broke open.

Christ's Healing Power

Forgiveness is not something you do in your own strength. If you could have done it on your own, you would have done it by now. The kind of forgiveness that heals deep wounds requires supernatural grace — the kind that only comes from the cross.

When Jesus was on that cross, He was not just paying for your sins. He was absorbing all the sin, all the betrayal, all the injustice of the entire

human race into His own body. Every lie ever told, every act of violence ever committed, every betrayal ever executed — He took it all. And He responded with forgiveness.

That same power — resurrection power — lives inside you through the Holy Spirit. You do not forgive in your own ability. You forgive through His.

""I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me.""

— **Philippians 4:13 (NKJV)**

Forgiveness is a process, not a one-time event. You may need to forgive the same person for the same offense seventy times seven times (Matthew 18:22) — not because your first forgiveness was fake, but because the memory keeps surfacing and the wound keeps aching. Each time it does, you make the choice again: "I release them. I give this to You, Lord."

And each time you make that choice, the wound gets a little smaller. The anger loses a little more power. The chain gets a little weaker. Until one day, you realize the chain is gone entirely — and you are free.

I have witnessed this in my own life. There was a person who wounded me so deeply that I carried anger toward them for years. Every time I thought about them, my blood pressure rose. But the Lord convicted me during a season of prayer and said, "You are carrying something I already paid for. Give it to Me." It took time. It took tears. But when the forgiveness was complete, I felt lighter than I had felt in years — like someone had removed a stone from my chest that I had forgotten was there.

Healing Prayers

A Prayer to Forgive Someone Who Hurt You

Father God, I come to You in the name of Jesus, and I bring before You the person who hurt me. You know their name. You know what they did. You know how deep the wound goes. Lord, I have carried this pain long

enough. I cannot carry it anymore. I choose today — by the power of Your Holy Spirit — to forgive them. Not because they deserve it. Not because what they did was okay. But because You forgave me when I didn't deserve it, and You are asking me to do the same. I release them from the debt they owe me. I hand the verdict to You. You are the righteous Judge, and I trust Your justice. Heal my heart, Lord. Remove the bitterness. Replace it with Your peace. In Jesus' name, amen.

A Prayer to Forgive Yourself

Lord Jesus, I have been punishing myself for things You have already forgiven. I have carried guilt that Your blood already washed away. I repent for placing my judgment above Yours. If You say I am forgiven, then I am forgiven. If You say there is no condemnation, then there is no condemnation. Today, I release myself from the prison I built with my own hands. I accept Your mercy. I accept Your grace. I accept that I am a new creation and the old things have passed away (2 Corinthians 5:17). Help me walk in this freedom daily. In Your name, amen.

A Prayer for Healing from Bitterness

Holy Spirit, search my heart and show me every root of bitterness I have allowed to grow. I confess it as sin and I ask You to pull it out by the root. Where bitterness has defiled my relationships, bring restoration. Where it has poisoned my worship, bring purification. Where it has affected my health, bring healing. I choose love over hate, mercy over vengeance, freedom over bondage. Let the blood of Jesus cleanse every poisoned place in my soul. In Jesus' mighty name, amen.

Prophetic Declarations

Speak these over your life with authority:

"I forgive those who have wronged me. I release them and I release myself."

"Bitterness has no home in my heart. I am free."

"The blood of Jesus is sufficient for every wound I carry."

"I am not a prisoner of my past. I am a child of God walking in freedom."

"God is my judge and my defender. I do not need to carry vengeance."

"My heart is being healed. My mind is being restored."

"I choose peace over pain. I choose mercy over malice."

"Forgiveness is my superpower because it flows from the cross of Christ."

"Every chain of unforgiveness is broken in Jesus' name."

"I will love again. I will trust again. I will live again."

Reflection & Healing

Reflect on These Questions

1. Who is the person you have the hardest time forgiving? What did they do?
2. How has holding unforgiveness affected your health, your relationships, and your walk with God?
3. Is there something you need to forgive yourself for? What is it, and why have you held onto the guilt?
4. What would your life look like if you were completely free from bitterness?
5. Are you willing to begin the process of forgiveness today — not as a one-time event, but as a daily choice?
6. Write a letter to the person who hurt you. You do not have to send it. Just get the words out of your heart and onto paper.

Forgiveness is not the end of your story — it is the beginning of your healing. Walk forward, beloved. He is making all things new.

A CLOSING PRAYER

Father God, in the mighty name of Jesus Christ, I ask You to touch the heart of this reader right now. You know the names and faces of those who hurt them. You know the depth of the wound. You see the unforgiveness that has turned into bitterness and become a wall between them and You.

Lord, give them the grace to forgive. Not in their own strength — because that is not enough — but in Yours. Let the blood of Jesus wash over every wound. Let the chains of bitterness fall away right now. Free them, Lord. Free them to love again. Free them to worship again. Free them to live again.

I decree that tonight is the night of release. No more chains. No more bitterness. The prison door is open. Walk out, child of God. Walk out into freedom. In Jesus' name, amen.

AN INVITATION TO CHRIST

If you have never received the forgiveness of Jesus Christ for yourself, today is your day. Pray this prayer sincerely: "Lord Jesus, I confess that I am a sinner in need of Your mercy. I believe You died on the cross to pay for my sins and that You rose from the dead. I ask You to forgive me and come into my life. I receive You as my Lord and Savior. Fill me with Your Holy Spirit. I am Yours from this day forward. In Jesus' name, amen."

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LORD, WHAT IS FORGIVENESS?

Forgiveness is one of the hardest journeys of healing, especially when the wound runs deep. This booklet helps the reader understand what forgiveness is and what it is not. With biblical wisdom, honest compassion, and healing prayer, Joshua Matthews leads wounded hearts toward freedom, release, and peace in God.

Step out of the prison of pain and
into the freedom of Christ.



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